7

Maoism Redux

13 February 1996 began as a fairly normal Tuesday throughout Nepal. No one, especially among the ruling circles in the capital Kathmandu, had expected that anything out of the ordinary would happen in any part of the kingdom. But, on that day, crowds armed with little more than daggers, old hunting rifles, and home-made bombs carried out simultaneous attacks on police stations in Rolpa and Rukum districts in the impoverished western part of the country, and in Sindhuli in the east. The stations were overrun and the attackers made off with guns, ammunition, and other equipment they had seized.

In Kavre, a local moneylender was captured and the attackers burned bond papers with the names of people who had borrowed money from him at extortionate rates. A similar event occurred in Gorkha district, where a local office of the Agriculture Development Bank was captured and its borrowers were declared free from debt. And in the Kathmandu Valley, Molotov cocktails were hurled at a Pepsi-Cola factory, partially damaging the building. Throughout the country, posters appeared and leaflets were distributed, urging people to support the uprising. Nepal's Maoists had launched their 'people's war' against the monarchy and for the establishment of a communist 'people's republic'.

But the uprising should not have come as a surprise. The year before, ultra-radicals led by Pushpa Kamal Dahal, alias Comrade 'Prachanda' (the fierce one) and Baburam Bhattarai had broken away from Nepal's mainstream communist parties and fronts, denouncing them as 'renegades' and 'revisionists' because of their participation in the parliamentary process. With the extreme left divided, and, its influence seemingly waning after the announcement of the results of an election in 1994, the authorities